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How IBA, a fashion start-up is using technology to promote CBT trade?

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How IBA, a fashion start-up is using technology to promote CBT trade?



BY - [Shipra Srivastava](#)

Senior Correspondent

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Indian Beautiful Art (IBA) was found to bridge the gap of global trade in the Indian industry for e-commerce platforms and inception in 2009 with a concept of e-commerce exports of Indian products internationally. The company has developed a Just In Time Garments Manufacturing (JIT) process, which helps to eliminate the need for warehousing for apparel and garments can be manufactured from scratch within 48 hours of receiving the order. In an exclusive conversation with Kapoor Co-founder of Indian Beautiful Art tell us more about the company.



Kindly tell us about your entrepreneurial journey so far. What was the inspiration behind introducing IBA?

I have always had the entrepreneurial mindset, I didn't enjoy my paycheck and knew in the very beginning it would not go for long as I was not doing what I love. The Journey continued until We saw a real problem and opportunity at the same time in the international e-commerce market, which leads to IBA been born. It was hard, but I never regret the same.

What is your assessment of cross border trade in India? According to you, what are bottlenecks in this segment?

The CBT trade from India is growing at a rapid pace. However, we are still far behind China, and still there is massive opportunity in e-commerce exports from India, yet the challenges from India which can party spoiler would be logistics, high payment conversion fee, expensive express delivery, GST Input Credit from Government for small parcels considered as exports & high manufacturing cost as per china.

The conditions have improved over the years, but there is still, which needs to be done in the mindset of the vendors and support from the government to produce high-quality products that match international standards.

Is IBA backed by any VC or PE? If yes, then pls provide the details. Else, Â what are the plans to raise funds?

We started in a small 10X10 Square feet room with 10,000 INR investment in the company, and today we have over 200 Cr of GMV done till today consolidated and this all is E-Commerce Exports Business, So that is the amount which we have got into the country from Exports (CBT)

At This stage, we are 5 Million USD run rate, and with JIT in our business Process already implemented today we have Virtual Inventory worth 1000 CR which can be developed within 48 hours after receiving the order, and via this, we are foreseeing 100 CR revenue run rate within 12 – 18 months.

All the profits have plowed back into the business as it is not VC funded company till yet and but we do plan to raise funds shortly via which we can have first movers advantage with JIT.

What are your pricing strategies and best performing product categories? Going forward, what are the plans for category expansion? Also, shed light on your customer base?

We sell products in a sweet spot of 20-30 USD, which means any international buyer is comfortable spending that amounts online, and we have further expanded our process to home furnishing as well i.e Just In Time Home Furnishing Manufacturer, POD (Print On Demand) Fabrics, and Custom wedding decoration & stationery which is in huge demand outside. Since we have the luxury to change designs so we can create a prototype and display the product with our AR technology Created Images, and create a product when the order punches In.

Tell us about your tech disruption in manufacturing space?

As per the introduction of Just in Time (JIT) technology by IBA Crafts, Just in Time technology promises to revolutionize the Garment Industry. The disruptive technology is the first of its kind in the world, the use of which dramatically reduces overhead costs & garments can be made within 48 hours catering to the need, requirement, and measures as the customer needs. With the introduction and inclusion of disruptive technology, i.e., JITGM (Just In Time Garments Manufacturing), which is also a copyrighted process with the Government of India, it is expected, this new technology will reduce the waste of resources especially water. Here, the customer will place the order via AR (Augmented Reality) Images, which will offer customers multiple ranges of fabrics/colors/prints/embroideries, and then garment would be produced within 48 hours after a customer placed the order.

At last, kindly highlight your growth plans?

We plan to start O2O (Online to Offline) model in garments where the customer would be able to check the physical sample of the product on the physical store and then buy the color or print by looking at the model image. By this, there is a great sense of satisfaction for material & size as this has already been tried by the customer and with our vast catalog of colors & prints on the model wearing the same dress

would attract more and repeat customers for new designs which we would be able to create.

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Swiss Military's Alpine Club Bets on Accessible Premium Travel Gear



BY - [Richa Fulara](#)

Features Writer

Aug 22, 2026 / 1 MIN READ

India's travel gear market is evolving as consumers increasingly look beyond basic functionality and seek products that combine quality, reliability, design, and affordability. At the same time, younger travellers are becoming more conscious of aesthetics, individuality, and products that complement their lifestyles. Swiss Military is looking to tap into this shift with **Alpine Club**, its new sub-brand aimed at bridging the gap between premium and mass-market travel gear.

“Either it is an inaccessible product because it costs an arm and a leg to purchase. And for the masses, you would settle for an entry-level product because you can't ever think of aspiring for a product that is beyond your reach,” expressed Anuj Sawhney, MD, Swiss Military.

Bridging the Premium-Mass Gap

The branded travel gear market is estimated at around Rs 7,500 crore, with around Rs 2,500 crore coming from the premium segment and Rs 5,000 crore from the mass segment. Alpine Club is positioned to address the latter opportunity while maintaining a clear distinction from its parent brand.

The brand's portfolio currently comprises 36 SKUs across three hard-luggage collections—**Miles, Helix, and Vortex**—with a market operating price of approximately Rs 6,500 to Rs 7,500. The offering also extends to soft luggage, duffel bags, backpacks, messenger bags, sling bags, and travel accessories such as toiletry bags, travel organisers, and passport holders.

“We wanted to create and curate a line” that would expand Swiss Military's addressable market while allowing the core brand to retain its premium positioning,” shared Sawhney.

A Brand Built for Gen Z

A key pillar of Alpine Club's proposition is its focus on younger consumers, particularly Gen Z. The Miles, Helix, and Vortex collections have been designed around lightweight construction, multifunctionality, multiple pockets, contemporary styling, and functionality suited to overnight trips, domestic travel, short getaways, and outdoor experiences. The brand is intentionally more youthful and contemporary than Swiss Military. The positioning is also more rugged, adventurous, and sporty, reflecting the travel and lifestyle preferences of younger consumers

"We're looking at trendy designs, we're looking at things that people really care about, which is being feather light, being ultra-modern. We're looking at fashion, we're looking at following trends, we're looking at a lot of influencers coming on board," highlighted Swahney.

Over the past two years, the company has worked on product features, colours, logos, pullers, trolley designs, and overall imagery to make the brand more relevant to Indian consumers.

Offline Retail at the Core

While digital commerce will be an important growth channel, Alpine Club is taking an omni-channel approach with offline retail at its core. The offline launch is already underway, while the online expansion is being rolled out in a subsequent phase. The company is working on online listings and A+ content while ensuring inventory availability across its 29 warehouses pan India. The strategy is designed to combine physical retail with marketplace fulfilment and quick-commerce capabilities.

Swiss Military has already tested two exclusive brand outlets in Hyderabad and Surat, with the company reporting encouraging visibility, sales, and market acceptance. It is now targeting around 30 stores by December and around 50 stores by the end of the financial year. The planned expansion covers Gujarat, Jharkhand and Bihar, the South, and Delhi NCR, alongside large-format retailers, organised retail stores, shop-in-shop formats, and defence-related retail channels.

Offline Vs online retail mix

Online currently contributes around 10 to 15 percent, with the company planning to significantly expand its presence across Amazon and Blinkit. For Sawhney, however, physical retail remains the foundation of long-term brand building.

"We have always been a GT, which is a general trade brand first because we believe globally also a brand stays in the long run if it is catering to the retail, offline retail market first," shared Sawhney.

According to him, online and quick commerce should complement rather than replace the physical retail ecosystem.

"The basic engine of growth in India or any of the global markets... is going to be your general trade, your large format stores, your shop in shops, your own exclusive stores, which is what builds the

foundation of the brand. Online can only be one of the extensions on the foundation that is built upon,” he added.

Two Brands, Distinct Consumer Propositions

A key element of the strategy is maintaining a clear distinction between the Swiss Military and Alpine Club. Swiss Military will continue to operate at the premium and super-premium end, while Alpine Club targets consumers looking for design-led, reliable products at more accessible price points.

Sawhney describes the approach as a “two-brand architecture” that allows the company to serve different consumer segments without diluting the equity of Swiss Military.

“Swiss Military continues to address the premium and super-premium consumers while Alpine Club enables us to participate more aggressively in high-volume and price-sensitive markets,” shared Sawhney.

The two brands are also expected to create an upgrade pathway, allowing consumers to move towards Swiss Military as their purchasing power and brand aspirations evolve.

“We are carefully differentiated to make sure that the synergy comes in and the cannibalization of the two brands amongst each other never happens,” he added.

Beyond Luggage

Although luggage forms the foundation of the launch, Alpine Club is being developed as a broader travel lifestyle proposition. The 36 SKUs include the three hard-luggage collections, while the portfolio is also expanding into soft luggage, backpacks, messenger bags, sling bags, and travel accessories.

“We’re getting into soft luggage also, and we’ve also launched backpacks, messenger bags, sling bags, and travel accessories,” said Sawhney.

The company plans to allow market response to guide future category expansion. Having spent nearly two years studying consumer requirements, price points, and product specifications, the next phase will be shaped by actual consumer feedback.

Building Scale Through Retail and Logistics

Alpine Club’s expansion is supported by Swiss Military’s existing retail and distribution infrastructure. The company currently has around 3,000 multi-brand outlets and plans to strengthen this network alongside EBOs, shop-in-shop formats, and direct retail. Its logistics network spans 29 warehouses, including 25 pan-India warehouses and four feeder warehouses, supporting faster fulfillment as the brand scales across channels.

The company is also investing in operational efficiency. It says it has reduced costs by around 7 to 10

percent year on year over the last three years, reduced overall ageing by around 15 days, lowered inventory holding by approximately 12 percent, and negotiated an additional 10 days of credit ageing with vendors over the past year.

According to Sawhney, these efforts are ultimately aimed at strengthening the business while creating greater value for consumers.

Targeting Rs 250 Crore in 3 Years

Alpine Club has set a three-year revenue target of **Rs 250 crore**, with around Rs 50 crore targeted in the first year, Rs 75 crore in the second year, and Rs 125 crore in the third year. The company is targeting around 5 percent of the estimated Rs 5,000-crore mass-market travel gear segment. At the same time, Swiss Military is targeting approximately Rs 750 crore from the premium segment, taking the combined revenue ambition for the two brands to around Rs 1,000 crore over three years.

The company expects Alpine Club to grow around 50 percent year on year between the first and second years, followed by approximately 33 percent growth between the second and third years. For a new brand, Sawhney acknowledges that the targets will require significant scaling.

“Rs 250 crore is something which does not come very easy. For the Alpine Club, we are looking at a very, very reasonable number in the first year,” expressed Sawhney.

India as the Launchpad for Global Expansion

Alpine Club is currently available only in India, but international expansion remains part of the longer-term roadmap. Before launching, Swiss Military conducted market research and sampling involving around 5,000 consumers, including existing Swiss Military users and consumers who had not previously experienced the brand. The company plans to use the Indian market to build a stronger understanding of the proposition before entering other geographies.

“Once the success and the learnings thereof coming into a new segment come on board... there will always be learning, there will always be corrections,” said Sawhney.

Strategic licensing and brand partnerships could also form part of the next phase. While Swiss Military already has licensing partnerships globally, Alpine Club is currently focused on establishing its identity in India.

Creating an Accessible Alternative

Ultimately, Alpine Club is attempting to occupy a space that Sawhney believes remains relatively underdeveloped: products that deliver better quality, design, and reliability without moving into the price territory of premium international brands.

“The objective is to offer consumers a great product by not spending too much while creating a proposition that is relevant to the next generation of Indian travellers,” Sawhney concluded.

Retail People

How V6 Clinics Is Building a Technology-Led Aesthetics and Wellness Ecosystem



BY - [Kajari Goswami](#)

Editor

Aug 22, 2026 / 1 MIN READ



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India's aesthetics and wellness industry is undergoing a massive evolution, with people increasingly becoming inclined towards self-care. A combination of rising disposable incomes, greater awareness of preventive healthcare, and increased access to credible information through digital platforms are some of the strongest drivers of this growth.

Speaking to Retailer Media, Dr Priyanka Sharma, Co-founder, Director and Chief Dermatologist, V6 Clinics, said, "Consumers today are not just seeking cosmetic

enhancements; they are looking for solutions that improve overall skin health, confidence, and long-term well-being."

V6 Clinics' Approach

V6 Clinics believes that the biggest opportunity lies in delivering integrated and holistic dermatological and wellness care. Rather than treating aesthetics, dermatology, wellness, and longevity as separate verticals, V6 Clinics is creating a unified care ecosystem where evidence-based clinical treatments, preventive wellness, nutrition, regenerative medicine, and personalised care plans work together.

Dr Sharma said, "Technology is another major enabler. AI-powered diagnostics, personalised treatment recommendations, predictive skin analysis, and digital patient engagement are helping make care more precise, accessible, and scalable while improving patient outcomes."

Scalability Strategy

Scalability in healthcare is meaningful only when it is accompanied by consistent clinical excellence. At V6 Clinics, the expansion strategy is built around standardised clinical protocols, technology-led operations, and continuous quality monitoring.

"We are integrating AI across multiple aspects of the patient journey, from digital consultations and skin diagnostics to treatment planning, follow-up tracking, and outcome measurement," said Dr Sharma.

These tools assist V6 clinicians in delivering more personalised and data-driven care while ensuring consistency across locations. Every clinic follows standardised treatment pathways, rigorous clinical governance, and ongoing training programmes to ensure that patients receive the same high-quality experience irrespective of where they visit.

Dr Priyanka Sharma added, "At the same time, we continue to invest in patient experience through seamless digital interfaces, transparent consultations, and personalised wellness journeys."

The company's recent seed funding provides it with the resources to strengthen its technology infrastructure, invest in AI capabilities, recruit top clinical talent, and expand its clinic footprint responsibly without compromising on quality.

Conclusion

As India's aesthetics and wellness landscape evolves, the industry is moving towards a more holistic, technology-enabled and outcome-focused approach. V6 Clinics is seeking to capitalise

on this shift by combining dermatology, aesthetics, preventive wellness and AI-driven personalisation under one ecosystem. With its focus on clinical standardisation, technology, patient experience and responsible expansion, the clinic chain aims to build a scalable model that can address the changing expectations of India's increasingly informed self-care consumer.

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How Swastik luxury Wellbeing Sanctuary balances personalised wellness with commercial sustainability



BY - [Kajari Goswami](#)

Editor

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Indians are increasingly shifting their focus towards fitness, nutrition, mental wellness, beauty, preventive healthcare, sleep, wellness tourism and personalised wellbeing.

Moving beyond the traditional Ayurveda-, yoga- and spa-led wellness market, Indian

consumers are increasingly willing to spend on preventive health, longevity and holistic wellbeing.

According to the Global Wellness Institute, India's wellness economy was valued at INR 17.23 lakh crore, making it the seventh-largest national wellness market globally.

Talking about the prospects of the wellness industry in India, Anushree Nyati, Director, Swastik luxury Wellbeing Sanctuary, told Retailer Media, "Global trends are already showing positive growth, with many international brands expanding their wellness portfolios."

She added that the opportunity lies in moving beyond the idea of a wellness retreat being simply a place to relax.

According to Nyati, the next generation of wellness hospitality will combine luxury, personalisation, preventive health, science, AI and authentic healing traditions.

"India has a natural advantage because our heritage provides depth that many global markets are trying to recreate," Nyati added.

READ: [Karmic Beauty Leverages Skye Air Network for Faster Product Deliveries](#)

Growing Willingness to Spend on Preventive Health and Longevity

Affluent consumers are increasingly interested in investing in their health. At the same time, they have become more conscious about what they are paying for and the outcomes they can expect from their wellness investments.

Talking about this shift, Nyati said, "Affluent consumers are not necessarily looking for

another luxury holiday. They want to understand what they will gain from the experience and see meaningful and measurable results, such as, better sleep, greater energy, improved metabolic health, cognitive wellbeing, healthy ageing or simply the ability to function better in their everyday lives.”

The desire to maintain a better quality of life for longer and age gracefully is also growing, driving greater interest in preventive healthcare and longevity-focused programmes.

“We are seeing increasing interest in programmes such as longevity, where the purpose is not simply to add years to life, but to support healthier ageing and potentially slow some of the processes associated with ageing,” Nyati said.

READ: [Beyond Beauty Shopping: How Tira Is Building a Beauty Experience](#)

Balancing Personalisation with Commercial Sustainability

As awareness around wellness grows, consumers are increasingly seeking personalised services and specialised expertise. However, for wellness retreats, offering highly customised experiences can also mean greater investments in specialised talent, diagnostics, technology and other resources.

This raises an important question that how can wellness retreats deliver highly personalised experiences while maintaining commercial sustainability?

Nyati believes the answer lies in combining human expertise with technology and structured systems.

“The key is to combine expert human intervention with technology, diagnostics, structured

programmes and a clear operating framework. This allows the experience to remain highly personalised without becoming completely dependent on ad-hoc interventions,” she said.

She explained that Swastik luxury Wellbeing Sanctuary is building a structured approach that brings together expertise across different disciplines while retaining the human element, which remains fundamental to the healing process.

Conclusion

India’s wellness industry is moving beyond traditional relaxation-led experiences towards a more holistic, personalised and outcome-driven approach. Rising consumer interest in preventive health, longevity, nutrition and mental wellbeing is creating new opportunities for wellness retreats and hospitality brands. As consumers become more discerning, the future will depend on combining expert human intervention with technology, science and personalised programmes while maintaining commercial sustainability. Swastik luxury Wellbeing Sanctuary reflects this evolving direction in India’s wellness landscape.

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Beyond Beauty Shopping: How Tira Is Building a Beauty Experience



BY - [Kajari Goswami](#)

Editor

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Launched in 2023, Tira has rapidly emerged as a significant player in India's premium and luxury beauty market. Backed by Reliance Retail, the platform is positioned alongside established beauty retailers such as Nykaa and Sephora, bringing together premium, luxury and mass beauty brands across online and offline channels.

Tira's portfolio includes global names such as Armani Beauty, Valentino Beauty, Prada Beauty, Versace, Dolce & Gabbana Beauty, Rabanne and Bvlgari, alongside Indian and emerging beauty brands.

Talking about Tira's journey and vision, a spokesperson for Tira told Retailer Media that when the platform entered the market, it saw an opportunity to reimagine the beauty shopping experience for the evolving Indian consumer.

“Beauty is deeply personal, and there is no single definition of what beauty should look or feel like. This thinking is at the heart of Tira's philosophy, ‘For Every You’—celebrating the many facets of an individual and recognising that beauty is as diverse as the people who experience it,” said the spokesperson.

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With this philosophy at its core, Tira set out to create a destination where consumers could not only shop but also explore, experiment, learn and discover products suited to their individual needs.

“Tira brings together a wide and carefully curated portfolio of beauty brands with technology-led discovery, expert consultations and immersive physical experiences, alongside the convenience of digital shopping,” the spokesperson added.

The brand's ambition, the spokesperson highlighted, is to make beauty more inclusive, personalised and enjoyable, creating a space where there is something for every expression of the individual.

Evolution of Tira since its launch

Since its launch in 2023, Tira has expanded from being a new beauty platform to becoming an increasingly visible destination for beauty discovery and shopping in India.

The spokesperson said, “Since its launch in 2023, Tira has evolved from a new beauty platform into a destination that is helping shape the way India discovers, experiences and shops for beauty.”

Tira has built an omnichannel presence across major metros while steadily expanding its reach into Tier II markets. Its e-commerce platform now reaches consumers across more than 100 cities and a wide network of pincodes, further supported by the broader Reliance ecosystem.

“We have continued to build a curated portfolio, including exclusive brands, while playing a role in bringing several global beauty brands to India and creating new avenues for consumers to discover them,” the spokesperson said.

A key part of Tira’s evolution has been its focus on technology-led and experiential retail. The platform has introduced innovations such as fragrance finders, vending machines, skin-analysis tools, smart mirrors and virtual try-ons to enhance the beauty shopping experience.

The spokesperson added, “Our flagship at Jio World Plaza in Mumbai is an embodiment of this vision—a beauty haven that brings together premium and luxury beauty with experiences such as the Scent Room, Beauty Suite and Tira Café, several of which are first-of-their-kind experiences in India.”

Beyond retail and technology, Tira has also focused on building a growing community of beauty enthusiasts through initiatives such as Tira Tribe. Its brand ambassador strategy similarly reflects its attempt to broaden the conversation around beauty.

READ: [The Body Shop’s omnichannel push: How digital, retail and tier 2-3 cities are driving growth?](#)

The appointment of actor Ahaan Panday as its male ambassador, alongside female brand ambassadors including Kareena Kapoor Khan and Suhana Khan, reflects the brand’s belief that beauty is personal, individual and ultimately “For Every You.”

What differentiates Tira in India's premium and luxury beauty market?

As competition intensifies across India's beauty retail landscape, Tira believes its differentiation lies in bringing curation, experience, technology and convenience together within a single beauty ecosystem.

“We believe our differentiation comes from bringing together curation, experience, technology and convenience in one beauty ecosystem. We have built a diverse portfolio spanning accessible, premium and luxury beauty, while creating environments where consumers can discover and experience products rather than simply shop for them,” the spokesperson said.

This approach is particularly relevant in the premium and luxury beauty segments, where consultation, product trials and brand storytelling can play an important role in influencing purchase decisions.

Technology is another key pillar of Tira's proposition, helping consumers understand their skin, virtually try products, discover fragrances and receive personalised recommendations.

Beauty's role in Reliance Retail's growth strategy

Beauty is emerging as an important and rapidly evolving consumer category in India, driven by consumers who are becoming more informed, experimental and willing to spend on products that cater to their individual needs.

Consumers are increasingly viewing skincare, haircare, makeup, fragrances and wellness as interconnected parts of their personal routines and self-expression, creating opportunities for beauty retailers to build broader and more personalised ecosystems.

■

“For Tira, the focus is on building a differentiated beauty proposition that can evolve alongside these changing consumer behaviours and contribute meaningfully to the development of India’s beauty ecosystem,” the spokesperson concluded.

Conclusion

As India’s beauty market moves beyond traditional retail towards experiential, personalised and omnichannel shopping, Tira is positioning itself as more than just another beauty marketplace. Its combination of premium and luxury brands, technology-led discovery, physical experiences and Reliance Retail’s extensive ecosystem gives it a strong foundation to compete in an increasingly crowded market.

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Korum Mall Adapts to Changing Shopper Behaviour with Stronger Spending, Experiences



BY - [Minakshi Sangwan](#)

Assistant Editor

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Retail destinations are being defined more by why people come, how long they stay, and what brings them back, rather than by what they sell.

In Thane, Korum Mall is witnessing this shift through stronger shopper engagement, changing spending patterns and a more diversified tenant mix. While retail remains central to its business, food, entertainment, technology, beauty and experiential activities are becoming increasingly important to the mall's overall performance.

“Over the last two years, the overall momentum in footfall has remained strong, supported by consistent shopper interest and engagement,” said Deva Jyotula, Senior Vice President, Korum Mall.

Spending Becomes More Purposeful

Korum Mall has seen average spending per visitor increase by around 15 percent year-on-year. According to Jyotula, the increase is being supported by more purposeful shopping trips, including during non-festive periods.

“Retail sales growth is being driven by stronger customer conversion and basket sizes,” he said, adding that changes in the brand mix have contributed to higher spending per footfall.

Seasonal events and holiday-led shopping continue to be important traffic drivers, accounting for nearly a third of overall footfall. At the same time, stronger engagement outside peak festive periods indicates that shoppers are increasingly visiting with specific purchase or experience-led objectives.

Large-format Retail Remains an Anchor

Large-format retail continues to play a central role in attracting shoppers and supporting sales. However, the mall's traffic is increasingly distributed across several categories.

Restaurants, cafés and the food court contribute to repeat visits and longer dwell times, while cinema and family entertainment continue to attract groups. Electronics has also emerged as a significant growth category as demand for technology products strengthens.

Beauty and cosmetics are gaining relevance as consumers spend more on personal care, wellness and beauty products. Essential shopping, meanwhile, provides a steady source of recurring traffic throughout the year.

“The overall tenant mix has become more diversified, reducing dependence on any

single category and enhancing the destination's appeal," Jyotula said.

Thane Remains the Core Catchment

Thane continues to form the largest customer base for Korum Mall. While the mall does not track the location of every visitor, customer registrations and feedback indicate that nearly half of its shoppers come from Thane.

"Mulund and Bhiwandi are among our key feeder markets, while we also attract visitors from across Mumbai and Navi Mumbai. This diverse catchment gives us access to a mix of local and regional shoppers," Jyotula mentioned.

Fashion, F&B and Entertainment

Fashion remains a key part of the tenant mix, particularly across lifestyle, footwear and contemporary fashion. Food and beverage is another important contributor to customer engagement, with restaurants and cafés supporting repeat visits.

"Entertainment continues to play an important role in family and leisure-oriented visits, while electronics and technology retail have emerged as some of the faster-growing segments within the mall," Jyotula highlighted.

The evolving mix also reflects the changing structure of Indian retail, where malls are increasingly combining shopping with dining, leisure and services rather than relying exclusively on fashion retail.

Digital-first Brands Enter Physical Retail

The expansion of digital-first businesses into physical stores is another trend visible at Korum Mall. Brands operating across fashion, food and beverage, wellness and experiential categories are showing interest in physical retail spaces.

The mall has also added digital-first and omnichannel names across categories. Jyotula said, "Interest-wise, both D2C and digital-first brands are actively expanding."

This movement highlights how physical stores continue to have a role in customer discovery, trial and experience even as online shopping remains an important channel.

Events as a Repeat-visit Strategy

Events and activations have become an important part of the mall's customer engagement strategy. Korum Mall hosts activations across the year, with around 300

event days annually.

The programme covers different audiences, from children and families to Gen Z consumers and local communities. Shopping campaigns, festive programmes, celebrity appearances, community initiatives and experiential installations form part of the calendar.

“Events and activations are a key driver of customer engagement at the mall,” Jyotula said. “They not only help drive footfall but also encourage repeat visits by giving customers fresh and engaging reasons to return throughout the year.”

Leasing Demand Remains Healthy

Like the wider retail sector, Korum Mall faced disruption during the pandemic. However, leasing activity has strengthened as consumer activity recovered.

According to Jyotula, the mall is currently seeing healthy leasing demand and a strong pipeline from brands looking for access to an engaged and diverse customer base. There is more focus on sustaining occupancy and enhancing the quality and relevance of the tenant mix.

Focus on the Next Phase

Over the next two to three years, Korum Mall plans to focus on improving trading density, evolving its brand mix and enhancing the overall customer experience.

The strategy will include adding differentiated brands across fashion, F&B, entertainment, wellness and emerging categories. The mall also plans to continue investing in events, experiential programming and community-led initiatives.

“Our objective is to create a well-rounded destination where shopping, dining, entertainment and experiences come together,” Jyotula said.

For Korum Mall, the next phase of growth is therefore less about simply adding retail space and more about keeping the destination relevant to changing consumer habits. As shoppers become more selective about where they spend their time and money, the ability to combine retail with food, entertainment and experiences could remain central to the mall’s evolution.

Retail People

The Body Shop's omnichannel push: How digital, retail and tier 2-3 cities are driving growth?



BY - [Kajari Goswami](#)

Editor

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Whether knowingly or unknowingly, we are all indulging, on a daily basis, in some sort of skincare and personal care routine. This could be because of the increase in the spending capacity of the average Indian or the rising awareness around personal care, thanks to the 'n' number of social media influencers.

Skincare, beauty, hair care, fragrances, and makeup are some of the segments of the beauty and personal care industry that are growing at a remarkable pace. As people become more and more aware of their needs and what is good for their personal care, brands that sell cruelty-free and natural ingredient-led products are experiencing massive growth.

The Body Shop, a British beauty and personal care brand, is one such brand that has seen significant growth over the years in the Indian market. Operated under Quest Retail Pvt. Ltd., The Body Shop is best known for selling natural ingredient-led and ethically sourced products. It opened a new store at the DLF Plaza Summit on August 13.

READ: [Geetanjali Salon Founder Sumit Israni on What's Driving India's Salon Industry Growth](#)

Digital or offline: What is helping drive sales?

The fast-paced lifestyle and rising pollution have compelled all of us to be mindful of the products that we let our skin touch. The real question is, how do we find products that are genuine, best for our skin type, in line with the climate conditions, and have the right ingredients?

For a lot of us, social media reels do the trick. Some search brand websites, some rely on a friend's recommendation, and some like to go and try products first before investing.

If that is the case, then how are brands ensuring product discovery and retaining consumers?

Talking about the same, Rahul Shanker said, "Today is not just about digital, it is about an omni-play. So, brands that know how to play the omni game are really making a mark. It is not just the online, but what really matters today is how you intersperse online with the kind of offline experience."

He also rightly mentioned that a lot of brands that started off as online D2C brands have now realised the power of retail and have started to open stores.

Shanker said, "We essentially have been a retail brand, but now we have become omnichannel. Nearly one-third of our business at The Body Shop comes through online."

How is consumer behaviour changing in Tier 2 cities for premium beauty and personal care products?

We all have to agree that the internet has definitely played a role in driving the rapid growth of the beauty and personal care industry. Because of quick access to information and the flow of education around personal care, people sitting in the remotest of cities now know which brands offer products that are best suited to their skin type.

Rahul says, "I feel that Tier 2 cities are not the way they used to be classically. With the penetration of the internet, these consumers in these cities are very well connected with the world. They know the trends and the brands that are making the right move."

He said that they realised this very well and hence, have a fairly good distribution in Tier 2 and Tier 3 markets as well. He mentioned that 40 per cent of their business comes from Tier 2 and below markets.

As The Body Shop steps into its 50th year and 20th year in India, it has a base of 40 lakh loyal consumers. Rahul highlights that creating this loyal base of consumers was only possible through providing a world-class experience at their stores.

How is The Body Shop planning expansion?

On being asked about The Body Shop's plans for future expansions, Rahul mentions that the brand is working aggressively on channel expansion and product portfolio.

“We are introducing a lot of product and 15 to 18 per cent of the range is actually new ranges,” mentions Shanker.

Conclusion

The growth of The Body Shop reflects the evolving dynamics of India's beauty and personal care market. It goes on to confirm that the consumers, today, seek quality, natural ingredient-led and ethically positioned products. We also understood, through this interaction that while internet is educating the consumers and spreading information, however, physical retail and immersive experiences still plays a vital role in retaining consumers' loyalty and trust. With nearly one-third of its business coming online and 40 per cent coming from Tier 2 and below markets, the brand is balancing digital reach with offline accessibility. As it enters its 50th year globally and 20th year in India, The Body Shop's focus on omnichannel growth, product expansion and consumer experience is expected to remain central to its journey ahead.

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Smoke Lab Vodka: A Premium Indian Vodka Brand in a Changing Market



BY - [Minakshi Sangwan](#)

Assistant Editor

Aug 13, 2026 / 1 MIN READ



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India's [premium spirits market](#) is increasingly experience-led. The consumer is moving away from the traditional offerings and looking more toward quality, unique flavors, and products with a stronger sense of identity.

In [vodka](#), this shift is creating room for brands that can offer something beyond a standard clear spirit, from Indian ingredients and craft processes to unusual flavour combinations and [premium](#) presentation.

Smoke Lab Vodka is building its proposition around this change. Instead of treating Indian identity and premium positioning as separate ideas, the brand brings them together through a vodka made from Indian Basmati rice, a five-times distillation process and a portfolio that ranges from classic vodka to experimental flavour profiles.

“Premium vodka in India has moved beyond being purely a mixing spirit to becoming a more considered, aspirational choice. Smoke Lab sits within this evolution by combining premium craftsmanship, Indian provenance and distinctive flavour-led innovation,” said **Varun Jain, Founder and CEO, Smoke Lab Vodka (NV Group)**.

Also Read: [How India's Alcohol Market Is Growing Through Premiumisation and Retail Reach](#)

From 2019 to a Differentiated Portfolio

Smoke Lab was founded in **2019** by **Varun Jain and Sanya V Jain** and is headquartered in **Delhi**. The brand describes itself as India's first-generation luxury craft vodka brand and uses **100 percent pure Indian Basmati rice** and Himalayan spring water in its production.

Its core vodka is crafted using Basmati rice and demineralised water and is distilled **five times**. The brand also incorporates Indian ingredients into its flavoured expressions, giving the portfolio a distinctly local dimension.

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From Classic to Experimental

The portfolio has been developed across different flavour and consumption preferences. **Classic Vodka** is the core expression, with a crisp, smooth finish and subtle citrus and mineral notes. It carries an ABV range of **40 percent to 42.8 percent**.

The flavoured range includes **Aniseed Vodka**, made with traditional Indian saunf and carrying warm licorice and spice notes at **37.5 percent ABV**. **Saffron Vodka**, also at **37.5 percent ABV**, uses pure Kashmiri saffron for an earthy and floral profile.

The more experimental end of the portfolio is represented by **Green Chilli Mango Vodka**, combining mango sweetness with chilli heat at **37.5 percent ABV**. The range also includes **Liquid Gold**, a high-end expression containing suspended **24 karat edible gold flakes**.

The breadth of the portfolio reflects the company's focus on flavour experimentation at a time when consumers are becoming more willing to explore alternatives to traditional spirits profiles.

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Green Chilli Mango Leads Sales

Among its variants, **Smoke Lab Green Chilli Mango Vodka** is the brand's best-selling product. The company identifies its Classic expression as an important portfolio anchor, while the flavoured variants are helping attract consumers interested in experimentation.

“Strong visibility, premium placement and clear communication around the product's unique proposition have worked particularly well at retail,” Jain said.

This makes merchandising particularly relevant to the brand's retail strategy, especially in premium liquor stores where consumers encounter multiple products on the shelf.

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Retail is a Two-Channel Play

Smoke Lab operates across both **on-trade and off-trade** channels. Bars and hotels provide opportunities for consumers to experience the product, particularly through cocktails and hospitality-led occasions, while retail stores support product accessibility and repeat purchase.

“Each channel serves a distinct purpose. Premium retail drives discovery and premiumisation, while on-trade plays a key role in influencing trial, cocktail culture and brand perception,” Jain stated.

The company also sees **modern retail** as an emerging avenue for visibility, supported by curated assortments and improved shopping experiences. Digital, meanwhile, plays a different role. While most alcohol purchases are still made offline, online is playing an increasingly important role in discovery and consumer engagement.

Also Read: [How Footwear Brands Are Expanding Across Tier II & Tier III India](#)

30+ Markets with Global Aspirations

Smoke Lab is available in more than 30 markets, including India, USA, UAE and UK. The Indian focus is on metro and Tier I cities, and the consumer base identified is Gen Z and millennials. Urban consumers are currently its fastest-growing segment.

The international footprint forms part of a wider expansion strategy. Over the next **two to three years**, the company plans to deepen its presence in key Indian markets while entering select international markets where premium Indian spirits have consumer potential.

State-wise Rules Complicate Scaling

For a spirits company expanding across India, geography is closely tied to regulation. Different states have their own licensing requirements, taxation structures and pricing frameworks, making national expansion more complex than simply extending a distribution network.

“India’s state-wise regulatory framework makes expansion more complex, particularly around licensing, taxation and pricing. It requires a highly localised approach to market entry,” Jain mentioned.

For Smoke Lab, this means adapting distribution structures and consumer price points to individual state conditions while maintaining consistency in its overall proposition.

Rs 1,600 is the Key Price Point

Smoke Lab’s stated price range is **Rs 1,600 to Rs 2,000**, with **Rs 1,600** identified as its top-selling price segment.

The company positions its pricing around the quality and craftsmanship of the product while remaining competitive within the premium vodka category. The focus, according to Jain, is on delivering value through **quality, provenance and experience**, rather than competing primarily on price.

Scaling Without Losing the Craft Proposition

The next stage of growth is centred on expanding into high-potential domestic and

international markets, strengthening the premium portfolio and accelerating exports. The company is also looking at collaborations across **hospitality, retail and lifestyle** as another route to consumer engagement.

The challenge will be to increase scale while retaining the characteristics that define its craft positioning. For Jain, that balance is central to the brand's long-term approach: "As the category becomes more competitive, maintaining product integrity while scaling operations is critical. Growth should strengthen, not dilute a brand's core identity."

For Smoke Lab, the road ahead therefore rests on a combination of wider distribution, selective international expansion and continued product innovation, while keeping its Indian sourcing story and craft-led identity at the centre of the proposition.

Facts

- **Founded Year:** 2019
- **Headquarters:** New Delhi
- **Core Category:** Vodka
- **Best-Selling Variant:** Smoke Lab Green Chilli Mango Vodka
- **Price Range:** Rs 1,600 to Rs 2,000
- **Top Selling Price Segment:** Rs 1,600
- **Key Markets:** 30+ markets / India, USA, UAE, UK
- **Top Cities / Tier Focus:** Metro and Tier I cities
- **Distribution Reach:** 30+ markets
- **Consumer Base:** Gen Z and Millennials
- **Fastest Growing Segment:** Urban Consumers
- **Key Ingredients:** Premium Basmati Rice and Indian botanicals

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How BytePe Is Making Aspirational Commerce More Accessible



BY - [Richa Fulara](#)

Features Writer

Aug 13, 2026 / 1 MIN READ



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As consumers, we often think twice before purchasing a product that is beyond our spending potential. We generally consider factors such as usage and value before making a decision. Many times, we choose to wait for a sale or save enough to make the purchase. This often requires us to compromise. To address this issue, BytePe, a consumer tech marketplace, was launched by Jayant Jha last year. The platform started with the core objective of making premium products more accessible to consumers across categories, starting with electronics and gradually expanding into lifestyle and other aspirational products.

“Most platforms today operate as single-transaction platforms where consumers buy a product and complete the transaction. At BytePe, we have built an upgrade journey into the buying experience. This helps address affordability through smaller monthly payments, while also giving consumers the flexibility to upgrade or change their products every 12 to 18 months. Our offering also includes bundled insurance that protects devices against physical damage,” said Jayant Jha, Founder and CEO, BytePe.

Today, BytePe primarily focuses on younger consumers in the 22-32 age group. As formal credit access remains a challenge for this segment, while their aspirations remain high, BytePe aims to bridge this gap by providing access to premium products through flexible payment and upgrade options.

Service Offerings

BytePe has two primary offerings. The first is **Subscribe to Own**, through which consumers can choose premium products and pay a monthly fee. This offering currently focuses on premium electronics, including Apple and Samsung smartphones, MacBooks, laptops, gaming consoles, and similar products.

“For instance, an Apple iPhone subscription starts from around Rs 3,000 per month. After 12 months, consumers have the option to return the device and upgrade to a new one,” said Jha.

The second offering is a **Buy Now, Pay Later (BNPL)** product for premium products. It provides a curated selection of premium products and allows consumers to pay over three or six months through no-cost EMIs.

Key Growth Categories and Expansion Plans

Premium electronics, particularly smartphones, are a major growth driver for BytePe. This category is growing at around 40-50 percent month over month and contributes 65-70 percent of the business.

Looking ahead, the company plans to expand further into laptops, MacBooks, and gaming consoles. It is also expanding into categories such as audio, including AirPods and brands such as Marshall. Lifestyle, sneakers, and travel are also on the horizon over the next three to six months.

“We believe credit-first commerce is a category-creation opportunity, and BytePe aims to be a frontrunner in this space,” said Jha.

In the long run, BytePe plans to bring the top 200 aspirational brands in India onboard across categories such as watches, sneakers, and travel.

Additionally, the company is working with multiple partners to bring a wide range of payment options to consumers.

“One of our key objectives is to bring affordability to every consumer who comes to our platform. A key KPI for us will be determining how many consumers visiting the platform are eligible for credit and how broadly we can expand access to premium commerce,” added Jha.

Metro vs. Non-Metro Share

Metro cities constitute a major share of BytePe’s overall revenue. However, the company is witnessing a strong response from consumers in Tier I and Tier II cities.

“While metros have traditionally been dominant, we believe that over the next three years, Tier I and Tier II cities could be at par with or even outperform the contribution we see from metros today,” said Jha.

Growth Plans and Long-Term Vision

BytePe has been growing at around 40-50 percent month over month, and the company aims

to maintain this growth trajectory. The company aims to create more credit rails and expand access across categories. Instead of chasing transaction volumes and scale, it seeks to satisfy consumers and enable access to aspirational products.

“We want BytePe to become the platform of choice for consumers looking to buy anything aspirational. When consumers think of an aspirational product, we want them to think of BytePe as the platform that can give them access to it at the lowest possible cost,” concluded Jha.

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Geetanjali Salon Founder Sumit Israni on What's Driving India's Salon Industry Growth



BY - [Kajari Goswami](#)

Editor

Aug 12, 2026 / 1 MIN READ



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We all remember a time when, for the first time, we went to the local beauty parlour with our mothers, friends, or elder sisters, and for most of us, that was our introduction to the salon phenomenon. Although I remember my uncles and aunts looking down on anybody going to a parlour.

They would often ridicule these set-ups as a waste of time and money. Cut to a few years later, the same aunts and uncles would mention their visits to a luxurious salon, where they received a good facial, haircut, or hairstyling. Gradually, what was once a luxury became a need.

Over the years, personal care has grown from being an interest to a necessity, and talks of salons like Geetanjali Salon became part of our dinner table conversations.

READ: [Why Oriflame keeps direct selling at its core even as beauty market expands over internet?](#)

Geetanjali Salon was one of the first in India to bring expertise and consistency, and hence, caught a lot of eyeballs very quickly.

Talking about the idea behind Geetanjali Salon, founder Sumit Israni said, "The journey of Geetanjali Salon has been shaped by a simple belief, beauty is an experience built on trust, expertise and consistency."

What are the factors behind Geetanjali Salon's growth?

He mentions that Geetanjali's growth has come from continuously evolving with consumers while staying rooted in its core values of professional excellence and service quality.

"Investing in education, building a strong team of skilled professionals and bringing global

beauty standards to Indian consumers have been central to our growth," mentions Israni.

What started with a focus on hairstyling gradually expanded across hair, skin, and grooming. The beauty and personal care segment is one that has seen the most growth in India. Beauty has moved beyond occasional grooming and has become an important part of lifestyle and self-care.

Sumit Israni says, "There is a growing preference for professional treatments, customised solutions and expertise-led services. Consumers are seeking advice from trained professionals rather than simply following trends."

What normalised the salon culture and raised awareness around personal care?

Now, the real question is: what made this change possible? The most common and obvious answer is the boom of social media and the internet, which led to mass awareness around personal care.

"Consumers today are more aware, more experimental and increasingly focused on quality and personalised experiences. Beauty has moved beyond occasional grooming and has become an important part of lifestyle and self-care," said Israni.

According to him, the Indian market is witnessing a growing preference for professional treatments, customised solutions, and expertise-led services. Consumers are seeking advice from trained professionals rather than simply following trends.

READ: [Retail India News: Billu Salon Eyes Rs 100 Cr Revenue Growth](#)

Along with the flow of information, the rise in disposable income is also one of the factors why people are inclined towards choosing value over price. The salon industry is moving towards a more consultative approach, where professionals guide clients towards solutions designed around their individual needs.

Sumit Israni points out, "Clients are willing to invest in services that offer expertise, quality and visible results."

How are Tier II and Tier III cities pushing the growth of salon industry?

Talking about the growth of the salon industry, Sumit Israni highlights that Tier II and Tier III cities are witnessing tremendous growth, with consumers aspiring for the same quality and experiences available in larger cities.

He also mentions, "Categories such as hair colour, hair repair, scalp care, skincare and men's grooming will continue to drive the next phase of industry growth."

Conclusion

Today, Geetanjali Salon has grown into one of India's leading organised salon networks, with 200+ salons across 50+ cities and a team of over 5,000 trained professionals. While expansion has been an important milestone, Geetanjali Salon's larger focus has always been on maintaining consistency across every touchpoint. A client's experience should remain equally exceptional, whether they visit us in a metro city or an emerging market.

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Retail People

Rupa Expands Retail Reach as Apparel Demand Shifts Beyond Innerwear



BY - [Minakshi Sangwan](#)

Assistant Editor

Aug 12, 2026 / 1 MIN READ



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India's [innerwear](#) market is steadily moving beyond basic functionality as consumers increasingly look for comfort, style, performance, and convenience across everyday

apparel.

For existing companies, such trends are also impacting the methods used to deliver goods to customers, with conventional retail now being supplemented by modern trade, e-commerce, and quick commerce. Rupa & Company Limited, one of the established names in the category, is responding by widening its distribution network and product portfolio.

1.5 Lakh Retail Outlets

Rupa claims that it currently reaches more than 1.5 lakh retail outlets through a network of over 1,500 dealers across India. While the company has not disclosed a specific retail reach target for FY27, it plans to deepen its presence in high-growth regional markets.

“Our immediate priority is to deepen our footprint with increased investments in high-growth regional markets where we see strong potential,” said Ramesh Agarwal, Whole-time Director, Rupa & Company Limited.

The company is also strengthening its presence across modern retail, e-commerce and quick commerce. Alongside innerwear, its portfolio is expanding into athleisure, kidswear and casualwear, reflecting a broader shift in consumer demand.

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Regional Markets Gain Importance

Rupa does not disclose its sales split by city tiers, but the company said a significant portion of its business comes from Tier II, III and IV markets. Its long-standing distribution network gives it a presence beyond metropolitan centres, while Southern and Central India have emerged as priority markets for further investment.

The regional focus comes as apparel consumption increasingly spreads beyond large urban centres, supported by wider retail availability and digital access.

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Modern Trade and Digital Channels

Modern trade accounted for 5 percent of Rupa’s revenue in FY2024-25, while exports contributed 3 percent. The company has not disclosed its complete revenue split across general trade, e-commerce, D2C and other channels.

Digital channels, however, are gaining importance. Rupa’s products are available through marketplaces and quick-commerce platforms including Amazon, Flipkart, Myntra, Ajio, Tata CLiQ, Blinkit, Zepto, Swiggy and DMart Ready.

“Digital channels, including e-commerce and quick commerce, continue to account for a growing share of our business, and we expect their contribution to increase steadily

over the coming years as online shopping adoption continues to rise,” Agarwal said.

For the company, these channels are not only sales platforms but also avenues for product discovery and consumer engagement.

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Portfolio Expands to 9,000 SKUs

Rupa currently manages more than 9,000 SKUs across multiple product categories. Its recent product additions include kidswear under the Peek-A-Boo range, Dry Fit sportswear, premium rainwear and other lifestyle products.

Athleisure is among the company’s strongest growth segments, driven by demand for apparel combining comfort, functionality and style. Overall business volumes grew by around 3 percent in FY2024-25, supported by demand across different categories.

“Consumers’ increasing preference for value-added and fashion-led products is creating encouraging demand for our premium offerings. At the same time, our economy portfolio remains a strong volume driver, enabling us to maintain a balanced portfolio across price segments,” Agarwal said.

The company has also been developing contemporary and performance-oriented offerings under brands including COLORS, Macroman M-Series, Softline and Bumchums.

Distribution Remains Central

With more than 1,500 dealers, distribution continues to be a key component of Rupa’s retail strategy. Rather than consolidating its network, the company plans to add distributors and strengthen professional teams in priority markets.

“Going forward, we intend to expand our distribution footprint by onboarding new distributors, building professional teams and strengthening our network in priority growth markets across the country,” Agarwal said.

The company is also focusing on inventory planning through technology-led demand forecasting, improved channel visibility and supply-chain optimisation. While it does not disclose its inventory cycle, these systems are intended to improve product availability and enable faster replenishment.

Managing Costs and Changing Demand

Input costs, particularly cotton and yarn, remained relatively stable for most of the year, although periodic fluctuations continued. Rupa said it is focusing on cost management,

operational efficiency and supply-chain optimisation to manage raw-material movements.

At the same time, the company is targeting a wider consumer base. Its expansion into kidswear, athleisure and casualwear is aimed at capturing changing consumption patterns among younger consumers and families.

Rupa has not disclosed its current innerwear market share or long-term revenue targets. Instead, its stated objective is to grow ahead of category growth through wider distribution, product innovation and a broader portfolio.

The larger retail picture is therefore one of gradual diversification: from innerwear-led consumption to a wider everyday apparel proposition, and from traditional distribution to an increasingly omnichannel retail network.

Facts:

- **Retail Reach:** 1.5 Lakh+ Outlets
- **Dealer Network:** 1,500+
- **Product Portfolio:** 9,000+ SKUs
- **Priority Markets:** South & Central India
- **Growth Markets:** Tier II–IV
- **Key Segment:** Athleisure
- **Expanding Categories:** Kidswear, Casualwear
- **Digital Channels:** E-commerce & Quick Commerce
- **Key Platforms:** Amazon, Flipkart, Myntra
- **Quick Commerce:** Blinkit, Zepto, Swiggy
- **Distribution Focus:** New Distributors
- **Portfolio Strategy:** Multi-Category
- **Brands:** COLORS, Macroman, Softline, Bumchums

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